

# ❖ STUDY BEES ❖

## POEM – THE SEA

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## About the Poem

"The Sea" is a short lyric poem by James Reeves built around one extended metaphor: the sea is imagined as a huge, grey dog. Across its three uneven stanzas, the poem follows the "sea-dog" through three different moods – hungrily gnawing at the shore by day, howling furiously at night, and finally lying peacefully quiet on a calm summer's day – capturing the sea's ever-changing character through simple, playful, sound-rich language.

## Paraphrasing

### Stanza 1:

*The sea is a hungry dog,  
Giant and grey.  
He rolls on the beach all day.  
With his clashing teeth and shaggy jaws  
Hour upon hour he gnaws  
The rumbling, tumbling stones,  
And 'Bones, bones, bones, bones!'  
The giant sea-dog moans,  
Licking his greasy paws.*

### Paraphrasing:

The poet introduces the central metaphor straightaway: the sea is a huge, grey, hungry dog that rolls about on the beach all day long. Like a dog gnawing at a bone, the sea's waves 'clash' and grind the stones on the shore for hour after hour, making a rumbling, tumbling sound that the poet imagines as the dog moaning 'Bones, bones, bones, bones!' as it licks its wet, salty paws.

### Stanza 2:

*And when the night wind roars  
And the moon rocks in the stormy cloud,  
He bounds to his feet and snuffs and sniffs,  
Shaking his wet sides over the cliffs,  
And howls and hollos long and loud.*

### Paraphrasing:

At night, when the wind grows fierce and the moon sways among stormy clouds, the sea-dog leaps up excitedly. It sniffs about, shakes its wet sides over the cliffs like a dog shaking off water, and howls loudly into the night – capturing the sea's wild, stormy fury after dark.

### Stanza 3:

*But on quiet days in May or June,  
When even the grasses on the dune  
Play no more their reedy tune,  
With his head between his paws  
He lies on the sandy shores,  
So quiet, so quiet, he scarcely snores.*

### Paraphrasing:

On calm days in late spring, when even the dune grasses are too still to rustle their usual reedy tune, the sea-dog quiets down completely. It lies on the sandy shore with its head resting between its paws, so peaceful and still that it barely even snores – showing the sea's gentler, restful side.

## Rhyming Scheme

The poem does not follow one single, regular rhyme scheme throughout; instead, each stanza uses its own loose, flexible pattern of rhyming and near-rhyming end-words (for example, *grey / day, jaws / gnaws / paws* in the first stanza, and *June / dune / tune* in the third). This freer, irregular rhyme – along with varying line lengths – mirrors the sea's own changeable, unpredictable rhythms, from its restless gnawing to its wild night howling to its calm, quiet stillness.

## Theme

“The Sea” celebrates the changeable, living character of the natural world. By imagining the sea as a dog moving through hunger, fury, and rest, Reeves captures how nature can seem by turns wild and threatening, and at other times calm and gentle – yet always somehow alive and animated. The poem's playful, accessible language and strong sound effects also reflect a childlike, imaginative way of understanding and befriending the powerful, ever-changing sea.

## Figures of Speech

### • Extended Metaphor

The entire poem rests on one sustained comparison: the sea is a giant, grey dog, developed and varied across all three stanzas.

### • Personification

The sea is given animal, almost human actions and moods – it “gnaws,” “moans,” “licks his paws,” “howls” and finally “scarcely snores.”

### • Onomatopoeia

Words such as “clashing,” “rumbling, tumbling,” “gnaws,” “howls and hollos” and “snores” imitate the actual sounds of the sea and of a dog.

### • Repetition

The repeated word “bones, bones, bones, bones!” mimics the constant, rhythmic grinding of stones by the waves, while “so quiet, so quiet” emphasises the calm of the final stanza.

- **Imagery**

Vivid visual and auditory imagery – “clashing teeth,” “shaggy jaws,” “wet sides,” a moon that “rocks in the stormy cloud” – brings the sea-dog vividly to life.

- **Alliteration**

Phrases like “rumbling, tumbling,” “snuffs and sniffs” and “howls and hollos” use repeated consonant sounds to add rhythm and texture.

- **Contrast**

The poem moves from the sea's daytime hunger, to its night-time fury, to its calm daytime rest, contrasting three very different moods within one extended metaphor.

## Questions & Answers

### **Q1. What is the sea compared to throughout the poem?**

The sea is compared to a huge, hungry, grey dog through one extended metaphor that runs through all three stanzas.

### **Q2. What does the sea “do” in the first stanza?**

It rolls on the beach all day, gnawing hungrily at the stones with its “clashing teeth and shaggy jaws” and moaning “bones, bones, bones, bones!”

### **Q3. How does the sea behave at night, according to the second stanza?**

It becomes wild and furious – leaping up, shaking its wet sides over the cliffs, and howling loudly as the night wind roars and the moon rocks among stormy clouds.

### **Q4. How does the mood of the poem change in the final stanza?**

The sea-dog becomes completely calm and peaceful, lying quietly on the sandy shore with its head between its paws, so still it can scarcely be heard to snore.

### **Q5. What poetic technique helps the reader imagine the sound of the sea?**

Onomatopoeia and alliteration – words like “rumbling, tumbling,” “clashing” and “howls and hollos” – recreate the actual sounds of the waves.

### **Q6. What is the central theme of the poem?**

The poem celebrates the sea's ever-changing, living character, showing nature as by turns wild and gentle, much like the shifting moods of an animal.